Students across higher educational institutions in 2009 expressed anger and discontent, and their frustration about how the elites benefited at the expense of the commoners. The lower strata were perceived to be bogged down with the weight of their day-to-day existence such as earning an income and sustaining a livelihood. This recognition of socio-economic inequality was considered a part of the status quo, where students, especially from the more elite institutions, did not question their own position within that status quo. There was a lack of self-awareness among the students in these elite institutions who often (though not all) belonged to business-class families but did not recognize their position as the elite. Their discussion of poverty and inequality within Pakistani society highlighted a sense of resignation and heightened alienation, both with the state and with their own ability to go against 'the system'. The students came across as pessimistic, not believing that a transformation of the system was even possible. There was a sense of helplessness, with the students believing that they cannot change the existing political structure because nothing can change in this country. The majority of the participants across the sample lost interest in politics: '*Don't feel passionate about politics*' (Student, Female, Karachi); '*I don't think that anything I can do could possibly make a difference*' (Student, Female, Karachi) was a common refrain. One student expressed the way they saw Pakistani society succinctly:

> *'Elite: unthinking landlords*
> *Upper Middle Class: unthinking burglars (party people)*
> *Middle Class: unthinking slaves at offices*
> *Lower Class: unthinking majority'*
>
> (Student, Male, Karachi)

While the quotes above reveal how the youth felt about the state at the end of 2009, a time characterized by violence, corrupt governance and insurgency, the sense of alienation the wider Pakistani population feels towards the state is nothing recent.[21] Weinbaum (1996) has argued that Ayub's Basic Democracy[22] was designed 'to keep the ordinary citizen out of politics' (p. 642). This denial of the right for political participation undermined the citizens by declaring them 'not ready' for democracy. This historical legacy also fostered alienation and lack of belief in a political system. The feudal political system based on patronage networks, still widespread among landowners in Sindh and Balochistan, works on a similar premise: those who own land should be elected as they know what is best for the uneducated and poorer peasants – who are often seen as 'not ready'